Do you believe in science?

It is difficult to believe in science because the whole point of science is not to believe. Every fact or law of science is based on what we call a **hypothesis**. A hypothesis is a theory. It can be **accepted as true** for two reasons:

- there is a large amount of supporting evidence
- it has not been **disproven**.

When both of these reasons apply, it has been accepted as science. People sometimes use the second point alone to manipulate information. For example:

> *Aliens built the pyramids. This has been scientifically proven because it has not been disproven.*

What evidence is there? A spacecraft landing zone beside the Sphinx? Be wary of the words 'scientifically proven'. Science has strongly supported hypotheses, not proof. New evidence may arrive any day to improve or disprove a hypothesis. Most famous scientists have had their brilliant hypotheses changed at some point.

☞ **1** Underline the statements that you think could be called **unsupported hypotheses**.

- My old house has ghosts.
- Crop circles are made by landing alien spacecraft.
- A car that hits a tree at high speed is likely to be badly smashed.
- Smoking won't hurt you. My granddad smoked and he lived to be 91.
- A parachutist falls slowly enough to reach the ground safely.
- My grandma tells fortunes. She said I'd meet a handsome, dark-haired boy and I did.
- The forecast says it will rain tomorrow.

2 Write two supported statements and two unsupported statements.

Supported statements:

- _____
- _____

Unsupported statements:

- _____
- _____

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